NoCaSS

Norwich-Cambridge Science Symposium

for Plant and Microbial Sciences

13th - 14th of August 2026

The Sainsbury Laboratory
TSL
Plant Health Discovery for a Sustainable Future

Department of Plant Sciences

Crop Science Centre

John Innes Centre
Unlocking Nature's Diversity

The Sainsbury Laboratory
University of Cambridge

University of East Anglia

NIAB

Earlham Institute

University of Cambridge

Day 1 | 13th of August

Norwich-Cambridge Science Symposium
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10:00 – 10:45 **Registration**

10:45 – 11:00 **Conference opening**

11:00 – 12:00 SESSION 1 – Symbiosis and microbial biology

Darius Kosmützky

Friend, foe or just also there? Cell biology and genomics of a fungus that loves Marchantia

Nick García Hernández

A mycorrhizal screening method for colonisation dynamics

John Palmer

A single-cell dissection of nutrient-driven epigenomic reprogramming enabling AM symbiosis

12:00 – 13:00 Careers panel

Tatsuya Nobori, Group leader at TSL

Hassan Salem, Group leader at JIC

Hannah Hodgson, Scientific Laboratory Head HotHouse Therapeutics

Reuben James, Account manager for Fisher Scientific

13:00 – 13:30 Poster flash talks

Chongjing Xia (3), Gideon Darko (5), Brigid Wong (9), Poppy Leslie (11), Gaia Galiberti (12), Emma Chareyre (15)

13:30 – 14:15 **Lunch & Posters (Odd Numbers)**

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14:45-15:45 SESSION 2 – Plant development

Pjotr van der Jagt

The evolution of tissue shape and differentiation in a computational model of plant morphogenesis

Kumud Saini

Mechanical cues in (thermo) morphogenesis

Becca Testa

The essence of senescence: transcription factor NAC3 regulates senescence in wheat

15:45 – 16:15 **Coffee break**

16:15 – 17:15 Keynote Speaker – Dr. Helen Fones

University of Exeter

"Surface exploration: learning how *Zymoseptoria tritici* survives and thrives on the plant leaf"

17:15 – 17:30 **Closing remarks & Group photo**

17:30 – 19:00 **Pub quiz & Dinner**



Day 2 | 14th of August

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09:00 – 10:30 SESSION 3 – Genes and genomes

Mishi Vachev

Identification and validation of candidate genes for resistance to mildew diseases in pea

Nicolas Trenk

Resolving the century-old mystery of Fusarium wilt resistance in pea

Samuel Bruty

Mendelian Mishaps: How breeding has shaped the rhizosphere microbiome and disease resistance in pea

Poster flash talks

Rituparna Goswami (2), Ella Mason (4), Jacob González Isa (8), Jade van Wijk (10), Asmi Maneri (16), Aled Griffith (32)

10:30 – 11:00 **Coffee break**



11:00 – 12:30 Nucleate presents: From Discovery to Venture

12:30 – 13:15 SESSION 4 – Plant infection, susceptibility and resistance

Lucy Bentall

The potential of 'persistent' viruses to enhance the performance of *Vicia faba*

Poster flash talks

Hana Azuma (1), Maria Florencia Bogino (6), Edward Harris (7), Elisabeth Graf (13), Marina Mitchell (14), Nathan Williams (30)

13:15 – 14:30 **Lunch & Posters (Even Numbers)**

Day 2 | 14th of August

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14:30 – 15:45 SESSION 5 – Plant infection, susceptibility and resistance

Beth Molloy

Unlocking the effector toolkit of a plant-parasitic cyst nematode

Rebecca Thompson

Phytophthora infestans suppresses host immune responses by targeting two unrelated helper NLRs

Mark Jave Bautista

Phosphoproteomics analysis identifies a novel group of phosphorylated effectors deployed by the rice blast fungus *Magnaporthe oryzae* during plant infection

Isabella Frost

Biocontrol activity of *Pseudomonas* spp. against *Pseudomonas syringae* pv. *actinidiae* is linked to novel natural product clusters

15:45 – 16:15 **Coffee break**

16:15 – 17:15 SESSION 6 – Biochemistry and metabolism

Julia Stewart-Wood

Wheat circadian clocks: molecular mechanisms of keeping time

Ted Holtom

Scaling protein-protein interaction screening via automated yeast two-hybrid and acoustic liquid handling

17:40 – 17:30 **Closing remarks and awards**

17:30 – 19:00 **Bus leaves for Cambridge**

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NoCaSS 2026 Funders

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